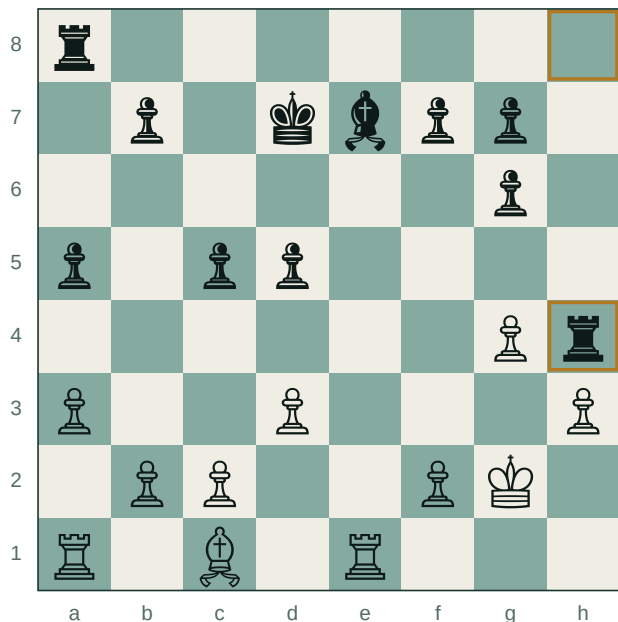


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 20

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 19...Rh4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Rxe7+ Kxe7 21. Bg5+ Kd7 22. Bxh4

20.Rxe7+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on e7. Recorded reply: **20...Kxe7.**

21.Bg5+ Check restricts Black to 6 legal replies here. From g5 it attacks king on e7 and rook on h4. Recorded reply: **21...Kd7.**

22.Bxh4 The bishop captures the rook on h4.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 12 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on d7. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.